it would be an overstatement to hold that the British deliberately and actively engineered the Nepalese immigration into Sikkim, there is no doubt that, in the earlier years, and particularly under the stewardship of Claude White, the first political officer of Sikkim, they encouraged and happily connived at it.'[9]

While labour was needed and few Sikkimese would want to be drafted into road construction crews or build houses in Gangtok and other towns being developed, the influx of Nepalese into Sikkim would also, Rustomji noted, be

> the surest guarantee against a revival of Tibetan influence. The Nepalese were mostly Hindus and their language was Sanskrit-based. Their culture and way of life had closer affinity with India than with Tibet…it was assumed by the British that settlement of a large bulk of an essentially Hindu-oriented population in Sikkim would preclude the risk of its looking northwards to Tibet for direction and support.[10]

Claude White's successors as political officer were more restrained when it came to encouraging Nepalese immigration, but the process he had set in motion could not be stopped. More Nepalese arrived and, already by the early twentieth century, they outnumbered the native population of Tibetan and Lepcha stock. Laws were passed to prevent the immigrants from owning land, but the influx continued unabated anyway. Many Nepalese also became engaged in various businesses. Francis Younghusband's military expedition to Lhasa in 1904 had opened Tibet for trade. Younghusband's troops had crossed the border at Jelep La Pass, which now became the main gateway for trade and other exchanges between Tibet and British India. Sikkim flourished in a way its eastern neighbour Bhutan, which remained isolated, did not. (The British political officer in Sikkim was also responsible for Bhutan as well as Tibet, although it was much bigger and an independent country.)

Then came India's independence and, on 5 December 1950, 'the President of India and His Highness the Maharaja of Sikkim' signed an agreement according to which 'Sikkim shall continue to be a Protectorate of India and, subject to provisions of this Treaty, shall enjoy autonomy un regard to its internal affairs'.[11] The government of independent India became responsible for the defence of Sikkim as well as all its external relations, 'The Government of Sikkim shall have no dealings with any foreign power … [and] the Government of Sikkim shall not import any